Before you commit the 2027 AI budget

Five questions for the sponsor about to fund the next tranche of an AI program, and what to settle before the money moves.

The pilot ran in a protected space. Scale runs through the real organization, with its incentives and handoffs intact. When an AI program stalls between pilot and scale, the usual cause is a condition in the organization that nobody checked before the budget was committed. A pre-mortem asks how the program would fail while the answer can still change the plan.

How to run it Ask each question of the people doing the work as well as the people running the program, and check the box only when both groups give a strong answer. Run it before the budget meeting.

	THE QUESTION	A WEAK ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE	BEFORE YOU COMMIT
☐	1 · STRATEGIC DISCONNECTION **Would ten leaders describe the outcome this budget buys the same way?**	*Each function names a different result, or the answers describe deployment and adoption instead of a business result anyone could miss.*	Write the outcome as a number: what moves, from what, to what, by when, and which executive is exposed if it does not. Settle that sentence before funding the work.
☐	2 · INCENTIVE FRAGMENTATION **Will the incentives survive the first real conflict between this program and someone's own targets?**	*Support is measured by who attends the steering meetings, and the leaders whose teams must change are still paid on last year's metrics.*	Check that every team whose behavior must change is measured on the new state. Resolve the conflicts you can see now, and name who decides the rest.
☐	3 · PROCESS FRICTION **Does the work flow the way the process says, or the way the workaround says?**	*The pilot succeeded because a small team routed around the usual approvals, and the scale plan assumes everyone else will do the same.*	Map the handoffs and decision rights the scaled program will run through. Redesign the ones built for the old pace before you ask them to carry the new work.
☐	4 · THE TECHNOLOGY ILLUSION **If the tool disappeared tomorrow, would anyone still agree on how the work should happen?**	*The plan describes the platform in detail and the changed workflow in a sentence, and success is reported as logins and licenses.*	Design the workflows and decision norms the tool is meant to change, and name who owns that redesign. Measure the work, with tool usage as a supporting signal.
☐	5 · MOMENTUM MIRAGE **What happens if nobody manages this program for ninety days?**	*The only name anyone can give for the program is the sponsor's, and the status report has been green since launch.*	Name a steward measured on the sustained result, with a written definition of a stall and the authority to intervene. Fund the role in this budget.

READING THE RESULT

A weak answer is good news early.

A weak answer to any one question tells you where the program is likely to stall. A condition you can name is a condition you can fix, and it costs far less to fix before the next tranche than after the post-mortem.

THE OPTIONS ON THE TABLE

Fix first, re-scope, or stop.

The honest choices are to fix the weak condition before funding the next phase, to cut the program back to what the organization can carry, or to stop. Stopping is hard to say to a board, and easier than explaining a year later why the second tranche went the way of the first.

Work That Holds
Built on the Five Breakpoints and the Stewardship Gap, by Brandon Freitag

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